

From the Polis to the Social Contract: Why Do We Need Government?

An original lesson plan inspired by **Steven B. Smith's** *Introduction to Political Philosophy (PLSC 114)* (Open Yale Courses). Not affiliated with or endorsed by Open Yale Courses or Steven B. Smith. Explore the original course: <https://oyc.yale.edu/political-science/plsc-114>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 9-12

DURATION

55 minutes

TOPICS

Political Philosophy

“Is government a natural extension of human social life, or an artificial device we invent to escape a worse alternative — and does the answer change what we think government is for?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain Aristotle's claim that human beings are naturally “political animals” who can only flourish within a political community.
- Explain the alternative starting point of social contract theory: a hypothetical “state of nature” that individuals agree to leave by consenting to government.
- Identify what specific assumption about human nature or the state of nature drives each thinker's conclusions about government's purpose and limits.

Materials Needed

- Short excerpt handouts: a brief passage from Aristotle's *Politics* (“man is a political animal”), and one each from Hobbes's *Leviathan* and Locke's *Second Treatise* describing the state of nature
- State-of-nature comparison chart (one column per thinker) for students to fill in
- Whiteboard for the opening scenario

Lesson Procedure

Hook: The Island Scenario

8 min

Ask students to imagine they are among a group of strangers shipwrecked on an island with no laws, no police, and no government of any kind. Have them brainstorm, in pairs, what would happen in the first week. Collect a few answers on the board — predictions will likely split between cooperative and violent scenarios. Note this split; it previews the actual disagreement between Hobbes and Locke about the state of nature.

Direct Instruction: Two Starting Points

15 min

Contrast Aristotle's view — humans are by nature social and political; a person outside the polis is, in his words, “either a beast or a god” — with the social contract tradition's very different starting point: individuals who exist, at least hypothetically, prior to and apart from political society, in a state of nature, and who must decide whether and why to leave it. Briefly note that Hobbes's state of nature is a violent “war of all against all” while Locke's is more tolerable, governed by a natural law — a difference that will drive the small-group activity.

Small-Group Text Analysis

17 min

In groups of three, students read their assigned excerpt (Aristotle, Hobbes, or Locke) and fill in their column of the comparison chart: What is the starting picture of human beings? Why, according to this thinker, does government exist? What would this thinker say government is not allowed to do? Circulate to check that groups are pulling specific lines from the text rather than only summarizing from memory.

Whole-Class Synthesis

12 min

Reassemble as a full class and build a shared comparison chart on the board, one group reporting per thinker. Push on the key hinge: for Aristotle, political community is part of what it means to live well; for Hobbes and Locke, it's something individuals rationally choose to escape something worse. Ask: does this difference matter in practice, or do all three end up recommending a fairly similar government?

Closure: Exit Ticket

3 min

Students write one sentence answering: “If you had to defend one of today's three starting points, which would you choose, and why?” Collect as a quick check for understanding before the next class.

Discussion Questions

- 1 If Aristotle is right that humans are naturally political, does that mean any particular form of government is more “natural” than others, or just that some form of political life is?
- 2 Hobbes and Locke describe the same starting situation — no government — very differently. Which description of human behavior without law seems more realistic to you, and why?
- 3 If government exists because individuals consented to leave the state of nature, what happens to that consent for people born generations after the “original” agreement?
- 4 Does the social contract tradition assume individuals exist as separate persons before society shapes them, and is that assumption fair to make?

Assessment

Students write a short response (one paragraph) arguing whether Aristotle's or the social contract tradition's starting picture of human beings better explains why people actually obey laws and governments today, using at least one specific claim from the excerpts.



Extension Activity

Have students research a modern example of a community operating with minimal or no formal government (a remote settlement, an online community, a temporary autonomous space) and analyze which thinker's predictions about life without government it seems to confirm or contradict.

Free to use, adapt, and share for educational purposes with attribution to Philosophy Commons. This lesson plan is an original work created by Philosophy Commons; it is inspired by, but is not a reproduction of, the credited course's actual materials.